After Independence, shortly after the ban imposed on the RSS in the wake of Gandhiji's murder was lifted, the organisation, through their schools (the Saraswati Shishu Mandirs) and *shakhas* (morning assemblies), started focusing on spreading a virulent history that demonised the Muslims as 'foreigners' and 'marauders' and tried to underplay or distort the actual freedom struggle. Apart from distorting and inventing history, faith and mythology also began taking its place. This has now led to top leaders of the RSS and BJP laying claims to such knowledge gems as the exact birthplaces of god-like heroes from our epics such as Rama and Krishna, or pointing to the elephant-trunked Ganesha as proof of plastic surgery being practised in ancient India.

Once they came close to state power, they tried to bring this kind of history into the national curriculum. In 1977, as a constituent of the Janata Party, they tried to ban the books the NCERT had got our most respected historians (such as Romila Thapar, R.S. Sharma, Bipan Chandra and Satish Chandra) to write for schoolchildren so that they had access to modern, scientific, anti-colonial and secular texts. Nationwide protests prevented this move. During their next stint (1999-2004) when the BJP led the central government, they first attempted to remove critical sections from these books saying they hurt religious feelings. Eventually, they had these books replaced with substandard ones with such a heavy Hindu communal bias that the Indian History Congress was constrained to bring out a book in 2003 called *History in the New NCERT Textbooks: A Report and an Index of Errors*, which concluded that these textbooks are "...beyond the realm of salvage, and they need to be withdrawn altogether". The books were removed, albeit after the NDA government fell in 2004, and a new set of books was prepared by involving a team of scholars known for their scholarship and not their political affiliation. It is these books that are at the heart of the present onslaught.



THE ATTEMPT AT ERASING A LONG PERIOD OF INDIAN HISTORY LINKED TO ISLAM COMES WHEN MUSLIMS ARE BEING VILIFIED

Now with the BJP once again in power at the Centre, the drive to change what history is taught to our children has picked up with renewed vigour. Noises by the BJP's top leaders about the need to replace the "concocted narratives" taught till now were accompanied by very selective deletions made by the NCERT in 2022 and 2023. Predictably, a significant amount of deletions relate to the Mughal and the Delhi Sultanate period. Following the deletions, Kapil Mishra, a very vocal BJP leader, immediately declared on April 4, 2023: "The lie of Mughals is being removed from history. Now, in the next phase, their truth will be told. Mughals' loot, adultery, atrocities, cowardice...their hatred of art, literature and music should also be taught."

It is important to note that the attempt at erasing a long and critical period of Indian history associated with Islam is occurring in an ecosystem where Muslims are demonised, Muslim-sounding names of roads, railway stations, cities, etc. are being changed and the community terrorised into moving into ghettoes. Globally, studies have shown that these are often impending signs of a genocide. And we know that open calls for genocide of the Muslims are now being made with impunity in India. This should be of concern to every citizen who believes in a democratic India based on the Constitution. Again, the deletions include all references to the Father of the Nation, Mahatma Gandhi, being assassinated because his pursuit of Hindu-Muslim unity was resented by Hindu extremists. This also occurs in an ecosystem where the assassin Nathuram Godse is called *deshbhakt* by BJP parliamentarians and the Congress, Nehru and Gandhi are held responsible for Partition!

The Indian History Congress, the most prestigious body of Indian historians, has strongly critiqued these moves. A large number of historians from all over the country have demanded immediate withdrawal of the changes, saying they are guided by divisive motives. Several state governments have also registered their protest, and articles and editorials critical of the NCERT moves have come out not just in the Indian media but in prestigious publications across the world.

It is time the discipline of history is left to the historians and not dictated by narrow-minded politicians with a worm's eye view of the world and human history. Indeed, textbook writing should be the preserve of bodies consisting of experts and eminent citizens, free of political influence and interference. ■

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